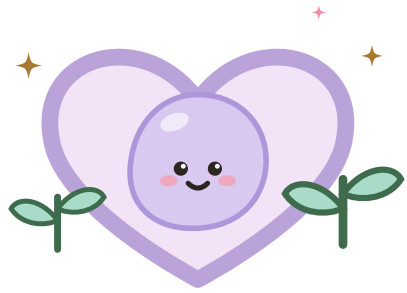
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 2

# Heal and Steady

*Stress, anger, worry, loss and repair,*
*and finding your footing again*



*by Christian*

Independently published
spreadloveandacceptance.com

*Spread Love & Acceptance*, Book 2: *Heal and Steady*.
By Christian. Independently published.

Text and pictures © 2026 Christian. First print edition, October 2026. Printed on demand.

**Free online, always.** Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com."

**Not therapy.** This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counselor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

**The examples are made up.** The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed briefly at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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# About this book, and how to use it

This book is for the heavy days. It covers stress, sleep and rest, anger, worry, low mood and trauma, grief, repair after hurt, the slow work of change, and what matters to you.

It is for anyone going through a hard stretch, and for anyone standing beside someone who is.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

| HERE | ABOUT | FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK |
|---|---|---|
| Chapter 1 | Stress and the nervous system | …/book/understanding-2-stress |
| Chapter 2 | Anger | …/book/understanding-13-anger |
| Chapter 3 | Worry, low mood and trauma | …/book/understanding-16-worry |
| Chapter 4 | Loss, grief and big life changes | …/book/understanding-8-loss |
| Chapter 5 | Healing after hurt | …/book/understanding-11-healing |
| Chapter 6 | Habits and change | …/book/understanding-6-change |
| Chapter 7 | Values, meaning and a good life | …/book/understanding-10-values |

Each book in the series stands on its own. Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, is about yourself. Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, is about understanding the people around you. Book 4, *Share the Load*, is about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 1, Chapter 1 (page 7)." The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

### FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

# Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| You feel flooded and can't think straight | Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system | 7 |
| Small things make you snap | Chapter 2 · Anger | 27 |
| Worry keeps you awake | Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma | 45 |
| Your mood has been low for weeks | Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma | 45 |
| Something frightening happened and it hasn't left you | Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma | 45 |
| Someone has died, or life changed all at once | Chapter 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes | 65 |
| You hurt someone, or someone hurt you | Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt | 81 |
| You keep starting good habits and dropping them | Chapter 6 · Habits and change | 101 |
| You've lost sight of what matters to you | Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life | 117 |

# Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-11 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as "Workpaper WP-11: The Calm-Down Kit." Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as "Tool: My weather today: the sky (the ladder)." You use it and it gives you something back.

*Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.*

## THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



**Professor Puddles**, a raindrop in a mortarboard, gives most of the hints, and answers questions on the website.



**Tidbit**, the quick, curious pup, points you at something to try.



**Sugarfoot**, the slower, steadier pup, turns up when a page needs a calmer pace.

*They keep to the lighter pages.*

## FROM THE PERSON WHO MADE THIS

> *"I spent my career as a government auditor and audit manager in tax enforcement, internal controls and compliance." "Everyone else seemed to have been handed a set of instructions about being human that nobody ever gave me, so I went looking for them myself." "Everything here exists so that you can do the same thing in far less time than it took me."*

*Christian, quoted from the About page at spreadloveandacceptance.com/about. Where the chapters say "I," they speak for the website and these books; any fact about Christian in them comes from that page.*

# 1

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 1

# Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

*What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they're flooded, and which kinds of rest actually put something back.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. More for your situation


MONDAY, 7:52AM

*The bus is late. One school shoe is missing, last seen under the sofa on Saturday. Your phone buzzes with a message from work that begins "Quick one," which it never is. From the hall your partner calls, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself shout, "I'm not your secretary!"*

*A second later you're standing there wondering where that came from. It wasn't the keys. You were behind before anyone*

> *had said a word, before the shoe went missing, probably before you were even out of bed.*

Feelings got their own chapter (Book 1, Chapter 4, page 61). This one goes a layer down, to the nervous system underneath them, and what it does when the pressure's on. Knowing how stress works won't make Monday any quieter. It does make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

It also explains why some of the tools elsewhere work at all. The stress tank in Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) asks how full you are before you judge the moment, because stress piles up from small loads. The Calm-Down Kit in Book 1, Chapter 2 (page 25) settles the body before any words, and it asks you to name a time to come back, so a pause doesn't look like walking out. And the setup score in Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27) counts stress as well as hours, since a split can look fair on paper and still leave one person running on empty.

In quick strokes: the surface is a missing shoe. Underneath it, a body already in alarm before anyone spoke. Underneath that, a week with no recovery in it. The roots are limited capacity and state and setting. Now one at a time, starting with the body.

01

### Stress is your body getting ready.

Something needs dealing with, and your body gears up before you've decided anything. Heart faster, breath quicker, muscles tight, stress hormones up. Which is exactly what you want when a glass is sliding off the table. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for hours and never gets the message to stand down.

Morag is a nurse. She handles a cardiac arrest on the ward calmly and well. She gets home at nine, eats half a sandwich standing up at the counter, and at 10:30 finds herself sobbing at an ad for car insurance. Car insurance has never moved her to anything before. Her body is still running the emergency it thinks she's in.

So after something stressful, give your body a clear sign that it's over, whether that's a walk around the block or a hot shower or one song played much too loud in the car on the way home. The body takes its cue from what you do far more than from what you tell it.

02

### Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same deadline lands on two colleagues on a Thursday afternoon, and one of them has a quiet evening ahead and a takeout menu. The other has a seven-year-old at home with a temperature and a partner away in Chicago till Saturday. On paper it's one task. Guess which of them is awake at 3am.

Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you've got to meet it with, whether that's time or energy or money or help or sleep. That's why a small thing tips you over on a bad day. It's also why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the job at all. When something feels huge, I'd write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you've got. Then ignore the first list for a minute and ask what would make the second one a line longer.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "It's less the task than how little I've got left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

03

## The ladder: three everyday states.

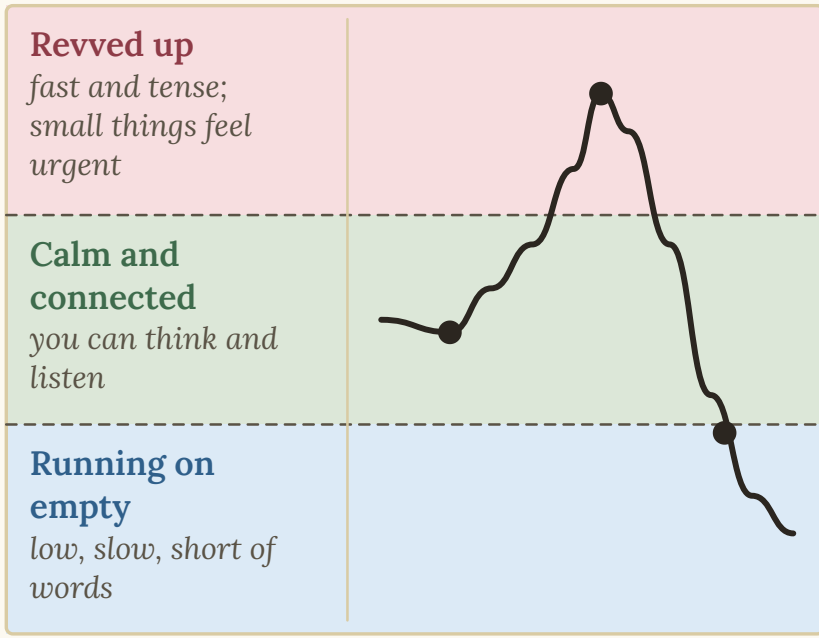
The ladder is a picture of the states your body moves between in a day. Near the bottom you're **calm and connected**, breathing easily, able to hear something difficult without bristling. Higher up you're **revved up**, tense, and small things start to feel urgent or personal. Then there's **running on empty**, which is low and slow, with the words just out of reach.

Most people go up and down it many times a day. Derek minds his granddaughter on Wednesdays, and at two o'clock he's calm and connected and they're doing a jigsaw. By four she has found the felt-tips and the wall, and he's revved up. By six, when her mom comes, he is sitting on the kitchen floor eating a fish stick off her plate and can't remember the word for colander. Neither of them had changed, only the hour, and how much afternoon was left in him.

The Nervous System Ladder is a thirty-second check that gives you a best guess at where you are. If you'd rather not use a screen, set three reminders on your phone for today, and each time one goes off, notice which called you're on. Don't do anything about it, just notice.

## The ladder: three everyday states

*You move up and down it all day.*




*Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.*

**Hard talks go best from the middle band.**

*Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.*

FIGURE 1 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day. Hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

**The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)**

*Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann*

## The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · Gusty: Revved up · *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · *Someone I care for* · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · Building · *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

*Barely slept* · Short night · About enough · Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work · Money · *Kids or caring* · *Health* · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · *Rest* · To move · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

**Fogged in today**
Running on empty · Very little room today

**Talk window**
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: “I’m at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?”

*A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.*

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

## When you’re flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve your body is in full alarm, and the things a hard conversation needs most (careful thinking, listening, seeing the other side) get much harder to reach. Lots of people call

this being **flooded**. You might say something you don't mean, or freeze, or want nothing in the world except to be out of the room.

Two brothers start clearing their dad's house one wet Saturday in March. Within twenty minutes they are shouting at each other about a standard lamp. Neither of them likes the lamp. Neither of them wants it. One of them says "Fine, take it then!" and the other says "I don't *want* it!" and they stand there either side of it, breathing hard, while the actual subject sits in the boxes all around them and nobody says it.

A flooded person is still a decent person whose body has to come down before the talk can go anywhere. Know your own flood signs in advance. Heat in the face is a common one. So is a racing heart, or the room going narrow, or a voice in your head that has gone very loud and very certain. Two at once is your cue to stop. Then say so in plain words, something like "I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

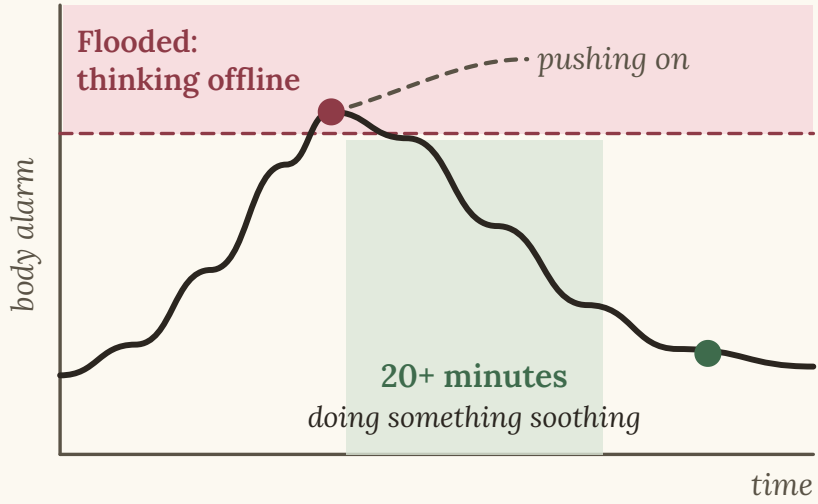
05

### Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Picture a tank holding everything you're already carrying today. The traffic goes in. So does the meeting that overran, and the noisy shop, and the text from your mom that just says "Call me when you can." It's all one tank, and by the evening something tiny makes it overflow and gets the blame for the whole lot.

## Flooded means offline

*Pause, settle, then come back.*




- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

*Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.*

FIGURE 2 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

Asked to empty the dishwasher, Kyle, who is fifteen, explodes. Really explodes, a whole speech about how he does everything in this house. It's days later, from a friend's mom at school pickup, that his own mom finds out his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime that Monday, over something said in a group chat. The dishwasher was just the next thing anyone asked of him.

Small daily hassles count as much as big events here, which surprises people. Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask how full you were before it happened. How much are you carrying? is five quick questions, and Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) uses it to tell old stress from new.

**Hassles beat headlines**

In a classic study, everyday hassles predicted how people were doing better than major life events did, even once the big events were taken into account. Which is why a missing shoe can be the thing that tips you over.

**Kanner and colleagues (1981)** · *Moderate: a classic study; many later studies agree*

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

06

## Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm. You can help the body come down, though, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths works for a lot of people. So does moving, or humming something you know by heart, or steady pressure like a heavy blanket, or simply leaving the noisy room. What works is personal, which is why it's worth finding your own short list on a calm day and not in the middle of a fight.

Before she has to give some difficult feedback, Bridie feels her heart going. She walks once around the staff parking lot, breathing out slowly past the dumpsters and the smokers' shelter, and goes

in a little steadier, if not exactly calm. Put your list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit helps you build it. If you only keep one line from this section, keep "body first, words second."

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

07

## Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the couch scrolling can leave you more tired than when you sat down. That's because recovery comes in different kinds, and sleep is only one of them, alongside switching off from work in your head, real relaxation, doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and the plain feeling of being in charge of your own time for once. None of them stands in for the others.

Two roommates have friends over on a Saturday for a takeout and a game show on TV. One wakes up on Sunday buzzing. The other spends the whole of Sunday in her room with a library book and the door shut, and comes out at dinnertime feeling human again. Company fills some people up and drains others, and neither of them is doing rest wrong.

**Four kinds of recovery**

Researchers who study unwinding after work separate four things: switching off in your head, relaxing, doing something absorbing that stretches you a little, and being in charge of your own time. An evening that gives you none of the four isn't much of a rest, however long you sit down.

**Sonnentag and Fritz (2007)** · *Strong: a widely used measure; recovery research is large and consistent*

Ask yourself which kind of tired you are, whether it's your body or your brain, or people, or feelings, then pick a rest that matches rather than the one you always go for. Calm sounds and music is one kind, if you like that sort of thing.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music

spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

## Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress land harder. After a short or broken night small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter, and people pull away from each other. This one is well studied. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm center react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), couples reported more conflict after nights of poor sleep. In experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier.

Saoirse comes off her third night shift at the nursing home and bursts into tears in the parking lot over a parking ticket. Her sister, on speakerphone, says, "You've had no sleep, leave it, we'll deal with it Thursday." By Thursday it is a parking ticket again, annoying and payable, and she pays it online on her lunch break between a granola bar and a yogurt.

You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story. Before a hard conversation, ask whether you've both slept, and if not, pick another time. At night, do the same few calm things before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

09

### Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other down. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder, or just a quiet person in the same room can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud helps too, because "I'm stressed about work" stops your partner wondering if it's about them.

Fish sticks again, Tuesday. Kwasi says to his ten-year-old, without quite looking at him, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my grown-up job, and you're not in trouble." His son nods and carries on eating. Nothing else is said. Over the next few days the boy stops tiptoeing around him, and on Friday he brings his math homework to the table again and asks for help with it, which he hasn't done since school break.

> MONDAY, 7:58AM
>
> *Six minutes later your partner is by the front door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry," you say. "I was full up before you opened your mouth." And then, after a moment, "Bathroom shelf, next to the toothpaste." They laugh, and ask if it's been a bad start. The bus is still late and the shoe is still missing.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Snapping when hungry or tired

FROM OUTSIDE A small question at the end of a long day gets a sharp answer.

THE LOGIC Patience runs on fuel. Hunger and tiredness drain the tank. With an empty tank, small things feel big. The snap is the fuel gauge talking.

IT'S LIKE A phone on 3% that starts closing apps.

WHY IT FITS Poor sleep is linked with more conflict the next day, and hunger can color our judgments without our noticing.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who asked did nothing wrong, and the tone still lands on them.

YOU COULD SAY *"I'm running on empty. Can we talk after I've eaten?"*

ONE SMALL STEP Eat first. Then come back and say sorry for the tone.

---

BOTH DIRECTIONS For some people, stress shows up loudly: a sharp voice, a slammed cupboard. For others it goes inward and quiet, and the first sign anyone sees is a person who has stopped answering. If you get loud, the quiet one may be just as full, only less visible. If you go quiet, the loud one is probably not angry with you. They are usually full, and it's coming out sideways.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Neurobiology's idea is that your state sets the volume, and stress left over from earlier still counts. Economics says the same thing in money terms: a household or a person running at full stretch has no margin left for an ordinary bad day.

---

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hungry-tired-snap

## In everyday life

Living on your own means nobody's there to notice when you're running on empty, so build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, plus the rule that whoever pauses names a time to come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space, spreadloveandacceptance.

com/pursue-withdraw, has more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is something they borrow for years before they can make their own. At work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, and waiting an hour usually beats pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, like shift work, a long-term illness or caring for someone. What that needs is a different setup. More effort won't do it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and Caregivers, spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers). If you have ADHD, just keeping track of everything can fill the tank before breakfast. Get the remembering out of your head and into the world, with labeled alarms and one hook for the keys, and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: make a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours



ONLINE
Caregivers
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

## Common mix-ups

People often think all stress is bad, and it isn't. Short bursts help you rise to something, and the harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery. Being calm doesn't mean not being upset, either. You can be calm and sad, or calm and extremely firm. Pausing gets mistaken for avoiding, but a pause with a time to come back is how you finish a talk well. Avoiding is the pause that never comes back. Rest gets called lazy, though bodies and minds that never recover

tend to break. And short replies with a flat face get read as not caring, when far more often they mean someone is worn out.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Nobody in the history of the world has calmed down because they were told to. A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence do far more. Taking one job off someone's list beats any pep talk. Ask what kind of help they'd like (practical help, company, distraction, some space) instead of guessing. Don't argue with someone who's flooded. Offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, say so kindly and help them find support.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder: a thirty-second self-check.

- Upset right now?: steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift, Brain Breakers and calm games: gentle ways to come down.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
Drift
spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer



TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes



ONLINE
calm games
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play

## More for your situation

- Book 4, Chapter 3: full tanks and different angles (page 51)
- How to stop fighting: calm steps
- New baby, sharing the load and Coming home after time apart
- For teens: big feelings and stress
- Sensory overload at home
- Help by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
How to stop fighting: calm steps
spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner



ONLINE
New baby, sharing the load
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent



ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
For teens: big feelings and stress
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Sensory overload at home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Stress is your body getting ready.
- ✓ The ladder: three everyday states.
- ✓ Stress adds up, like a tank filling.
- ✓ Rest isn't one thing.
- ✓ Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles**
*The stress tank in a shared home*
Share the Load, page 51

**Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words**
*Your weather before you speak*
Know Yourself Kindly, page 25

**Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune**
*How stress knocks two people out of tune*
Understanding Each Other, page 7

PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
Workpaper · free to print: Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**My weather today: the sky (the ladder)**
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth

# 2

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 2

# Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

*What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterward, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. More for your situation


TUESDAY, 6:10PM

*Your brother. Cant do thurs after all sorry!! work thing*

*Thursday is Mom's hospital appointment. The one with the specialist, the one you've been going on about for three weeks, and it's the third time this month he's done this. Your jaw goes and your face goes hot. Your thumbs are already moving,* TYPICAL. *You never, and the message is one tap from sent.*

Plenty of us were taught that anger was rude, or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is an

ordinary human feeling, though, and it very often points at something real. It also sits under two tools elsewhere. The Calm-Down Kit (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25) works because anger rises in the body first and slowing the body is what makes words possible. And letting a comment land before you react (Book 4, Chapter 4, page 73) is the stepping back described further on.

The canceled appointment, seen quickly. The surface is a sibling who let you down again. Underneath, anger, fast and hot. Underneath that, fear about Mom and tiredness. The roots are signal and noise, and state and setting. The chapter goes back through those layers slowly.

01

## Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says something is unfair, or something's in your way, or a line has been crossed. It pushes you *toward* a problem so you'll change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or come out far bigger than the thing in front of it.

Somebody keeps eating Shabnam's lunch from the office fridge. Week one, she assumes a mistake. Week two, she writes her name on the box in marker pen. Week three, the box is empty again and has been put back in the fridge, neatly, with the lid on, which is the bit that does it. Her anger has now told her very clearly that a line has been crossed, and it's the anger, frankly, that gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting. (It was the new starter. He thought the fridge

**Anger moves you toward things**
Most unpleasant feelings make us back away. A review by Carver and Harmon-Jones argued that anger usually does the opposite: like eagerness, it pushes you toward the goal or the obstacle. That's what makes it good at showing what matters, and risky to act on at full heat.

**Carver and Harmon-Jones (2009)** · *Moderate: an influential review; the approach view is still debated*

was communal. He bought her a meal deal and looked like he wanted to die.)

Next time you're angry, finish this privately. "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

02

## Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than whatever is under it, which is often hurt, or fear, or shame, or plain exhaustion. Book 1, Chapter 4 (page 61) calls this layers, and the layer underneath usually tells you what you actually need.

Frankie was an hour late home. She is sixteen. Her dad was waiting in the hall when the key went in the door and what came out of him was mostly about curfews and rules and respect, at volume. She gave as good as she got. It was only later, sitting on the stairs, that he told her about the hour itself. Standing at the front window. Phone in his hand. Checking the bus app over and over. Working out which ER. She went quiet then. "Sorry," she said, and this time she meant it.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across as angry, but I think I'm actually hurt."

03

## Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart and a voice going up are the body getting ready for a fight, and it takes seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking gets a lot harder, and listening harder still. Chapter 1 (page 7) calls this being flooded.

Halfway through an argument about the trash (whose turn, and also, it emerged, whose turn for the last four years) Meera noticed that her hands were shaking. She also realized she hadn't heard a single thing her roommate had said for at least a minute. She'd been composing, and that was her sign. Learn your own early signs, if you can, whether it's a tight jaw or talking faster or being very, very reasonable in a slightly high voice.

04

### In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

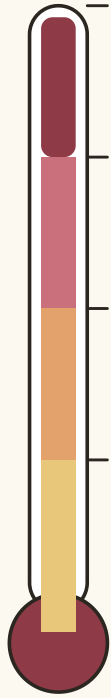
When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking. Stop typing. Breathe out slowly, so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath. Unclench your hands. If you can, get out of the room for a bit. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

Fractions, at the kitchen table, 7:30, question four. Ben could feel his voice getting tighter with every "But *why* is it a half?" "I'm getting frustrated," he said in the end, "and that's not your fault. I'm getting a glass of water. Five minutes." He stood at the sink, looking out at the dark backyard, and drank the whole glass. When he came back they did the rest of the sheet together, and both of them got number six wrong, confidently.

Make the plan on a calm day. Your early sign, the words you'll say, where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? has steps for the very worst moments.

## Anger rises fast

*What helps depends on how hot it is.*



**Hot minutes**
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

**Angry**
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

**Annoyed**
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

**Irritated**
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

**Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.**
Then repair any sharp moments.

*In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help.*

FIGURE 3 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first. Letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

**The Calm-Down Kit**

*Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13*

## The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
*Pat (Grandma)*

Date
*October 4, 2026*

### Part A: What tends to start it

| What tends to start it | How it shows up in my body first |
|---|---|
| *Door slammed after a call with his mom* | *Shoulders up by my ears* |
| *Being shouted at in front of the neighbors* | *Hot face, can't find words* |

### Part A: My two defaults

First default
*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*

Second, if the first isn't available
*Low, steady sound*

### Part A: My pause line

In my words
*I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm making tea for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you in half an hour.*

### Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
*"Coffee break"*

The shortest break we take
*20 minutes*

How we set the time to come back
*Whoever pauses says a time before they go*

The first sentence when we come back
*"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."*

### Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

### Part C: Coming back

| Time | What I did | How I feel now |
|---|---|---|
| 5:10pm | *Gating (lower the lights, step out)* | *Settled enough* |

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

**Next**

Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action

*Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule*

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up

*After tea, at 6*

☑ I'm going with this

*Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating," one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.*

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

05

## Letting rip doesn't empty it.

A lot of people believe anger works like steam. Shout, slam a door, hit a pillow, and it's out, and you're calmer. It's a lovely tidy idea. The research doesn't support it. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even toward someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger fades faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

After a fight with a colleague, Neville spent his lunch break telling three separate people how awful she was. Each telling got a bit better. By two o'clock he was angrier than he'd been at noon, and had a headache. The next time it happened he walked to the river and back instead and didn't tell anyone anything, which nearly killed him. By two he could think about the actual problem. He still thinks she was out of order, and says so, but at a normal volume and to fewer people.

06

## Step back and look from the outside.

Once your body has come down a bit, try looking at the moment as if you were watching from the other side of the room. What actually happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall," instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less

aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

One way in is to write two lines about it in the third person, with your own name. “Wes got angry because…” It feels a bit mad. It works annoyingly well. Wes himself, canceled on by a friend for the third time, got as far as “Wes got angry because Matt canceled again, and Matt is…” and stopped, because Matt is looking after his dad, who has been in and out of the hospital since June. The anger didn’t go. It turned, slowly, into worry, which was at least pointing the right way.

07

### Say it, don’t throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you’re calmer you can still say you were angry, and why, without going for anyone, by keeping to what happened and how you felt and what you’re asking for.

“You always let me down” was what Carol wanted to say to her sister. What she actually sent, after two drafts and a cup of tea, was this. “When you canceled Mom’s appointment again I felt really angry, and on my own with it. Can we sort out who takes her for the next three months?” It’s longer, and it is also the only version that gets anyone to the hospital. Book 3, Chapter 2 (page 23) has more on saying hard things.

**Two versions of the same fight**

When people wrote about a time they angered someone and a time someone angered them, the two kinds of story differed in how serious the harm seemed, how understandable it was and whether it was over. Same sort of event, told from two different places.

**Baumeister, Stillwell and Wotman (1990)** · *Moderate: a classic study of people’s own written memories*

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?" "When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."



SUGARFOOT

Say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it far easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment
spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

## After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a lot, because a short, real repair rebuilds trust. Name what you did, with no "but" on the end, and say what you'll do differently.

The blue vase from the hall table is on the floor in about nine pieces and Grandma Jean has just shouted, really shouted, and Jayden is crying. An hour later she finds him on the stairs. She sits down next to him, which takes her a while with her knees. "I shouted, and that was scary," she says. "You matter to me far more than any vase. I'm sorry." He leans on her shoulder for a bit, and then he asks if they can glue it, so they try. It now has a very visible

crack and lives on the landing, where she says it reminds her of something. Chapter 5 (page 81) has more on apologies that land.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry."
> "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

09

### When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, or shouting so someone is scared. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

Being angry, even loudly, is different from intimidation. Anger becomes intimidation when these are present together: it happens again and again, it arrives when the other person disagrees or says no, it decides what happens next, and people start changing what they say and do to avoid it. A raised voice in one hard conversation that gets repaired isn't that. Neither is being loud by nature, saying a strong feeling plainly, or crying and shouting during a meltdown. Ask yourself whether your anger passes and gets repaired, and whether the other person can still say no to you.

For example, a man realizes his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they have started keeping out of his way, and he decides to do something about it.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

*You put the phone face down on the arm of the sofa and walk around the block, breathing out long and feeling slightly silly about it, and somewhere near the postbox on the corner you notice what's underneath, which is that you're tired and you're frightened about Mom. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel on my own with Mom's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"*

*He reads it at 6:52. By ten there's still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who's driving her on Thursday.*

## If you're a teenager

Ten o'clock, and Maisie's dad has taken her phone. Right in the middle of a group chat about Saturday. She shouts and slams her bedroom door hard enough to rattle the picture on the landing, and then lies on her bed composing speeches. The next morning, calmer and also starving, she tells him it felt like he didn't trust her, says sorry about the door, and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He says fine. He also says he'd much rather hear this over breakfast than through a door, which she thinks is a bit much, but lets go.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and the fights often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Getting upset over something "small"

FROM OUTSIDE After a long day, a cup left on the counter leads to an outburst.

THE LOGIC Stress adds up all day. Each thing fills a glass a little more. The cup is the last drop. What spills is the whole glass.

IT'S LIKE One more breath into a balloon that was already full.

WHY IT FITS The last small thing often gets the reaction that belongs to the whole day.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who left the cup gets a whole day poured over them.

YOU COULD SAY *"It's not just the cup. It's been a heavy day."*

ONE SMALL STEP Say early when the glass is getting full. Afterward, apologize for the size of the reaction.

---

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people say anger fast and plainly and are over it within minutes. Others go very quiet and very polite, and it can last for days. If you're quick, the quiet person may still be furious long after you've moved on, so check. If you're slow and quiet, the quick one's outburst may be bigger in sound than in meaning. Both versions carry the same message: something mattered.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET The art of debating offers a useful rule for the hot minutes: separate the claim from the person, and say the strongest version of their point first. Music explains why it so often goes wrong anyway, because tone and tempo carry more than the words, and a rising voice is heard before any sentence is.

---

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-straw

## In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward, and it helps to talk to yourself the way you would to a friend who'd done the same thing (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 79, goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more

than anything we say about it. At work anger is common and rarely spoken, and "I'm frustrated about the deadline change, can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can come fast and big and go just as fast, so plan for the speed. A three-word pause line ("Back in ten") and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you're managing a clash between two other people, hear each of them on their own first and then together, always about what happened and never about each other. Quite often the fight is about the setup, two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example.

## Common mix-ups

Anger itself isn't a bad feeling. It's normal and it carries information, and it's some of the things done in anger that cause harm. Letting it out isn't the healthy option it sounds like, because shouting and hitting things tend to keep anger going. "They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted" mixes up two separate things. Someone can do something unfair, and what you do next is still yours. And holding it in isn't as safe as it looks. Anger swallowed for years comes out sideways, as coldness or sarcasm or a sudden explosion over a teaspoon, so saying it calmly and early is the safer road.

## If you want to help someone else with this

You don't have to stay and calm someone down. If you do stay, speak lower and slower and leave the argument until they've come down. Then listen for the message underneath. There's often something fair in it, and you can take that part seriously while still saying the way it came out wasn't okay. Something like "I want to

hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" keeps hold of both halves.

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

## More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
- For teens
- Family rifts · Caring for someone you love

- At work
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- ✓ **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- ✓ **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.
- ✓ **Anger that hurts someone has become harm.** The feeling is yours to own, and so is what you do with it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles**
*Leftover stress behind a reaction*
Share the Load, page 51

**Book 1, Chapter 4 · How feelings work**
*Feelings as signals*
Know Yourself Kindly, page 61

**Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt**
*Repair after the hot minutes*
page 81

**Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming**
*A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day*
Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**Cool-down corner: Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth

# 3

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 3

# Worry, low mood and trauma

*How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, and how to support someone. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Therapy helps many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 1 (page 7). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.

- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- **Therapy works for many people, and so can medicines.**

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

*The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice and the back door once, and you're thinking about the front door again. Tomorrow is the hospital, ten o'clock, and it goes round and round. What if it's bad. What if I can't cope. Who would I even tell.*

*And if you're honest, it isn't only tonight. You haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks. Even replying to a text has started to feel like lifting something.*

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people it settles by itself, and for others it sticks, and grows, until it shapes every day. This chapter is about how these things work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you aren't alone in it, and it can get better.

Some tools elsewhere lean on this chapter. The daily check-in's "low, medium or high" (Book 3, Chapter 1, page 7) lets people adjust when worry or low mood has shrunk the room you have. "A full tank means later, not never" (Book 4, Chapter 3, page 51) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going. And picking one small goal (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 45) suits low mood, since doing very often comes before feeling better.

Quickly, then slowly. On the surface, checking the door twice. Underneath, an alarm that keeps going off with nothing to point at. Underneath that, sleep, people and days that have narrowed. The roots are state and setting, and feedback loops, since avoiding keeps the alarm going. The rest of the chapter takes each part in turn.

01

## Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that's here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen. Worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" going round. All three run through the stress system from Chapter 1 (page 7), which is why they come with a racing heart and a tight chest and a churning stomach and nights of bad sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is it can be set far too sensitive, and it can't tell a tiger from an email.

Before every presentation in class, Leah's heart hammers so hard her hands shake her notes. She is fifteen, and nothing bad has ever happened to her in a presentation. Her alarm still treats a room full of people she's known since first grade, one of whom once ate a worm for 50 cents, as somewhere dangerous.

**Fear of not knowing**

One review argues that fear of the unknown, the not-knowing itself, may sit underneath a lot of anxiety. It's a proposal rather than a settled finding, but it fits the night before a hospital appointment better than most explanations do.

**Carleton (2016)** · *Theory: an influential review; the central claim is a proposal*

When it rises, try breathing out slowly five times, each breath out longer than the breath in. Then name three things you can see. It tells the body the danger isn't here right now, and while it won't switch the alarm off, it can usually turn it down a notch.

02

## Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was clever. So next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back toward the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to find out you can cope. Psychologists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on the 42, Graham started walking everywhere, in the rain, three miles to work and three miles back. His sister didn't argue. One Saturday she just stood at the bus stop with him and they got on, and off again, after one stop. A week later, two stops. It took most of the spring before he did the whole run into town, sitting by the doors, feeling sick, reading the same ad for a lawyer over and over. But he did it, and his brain had slowly learned that buses are survivable.

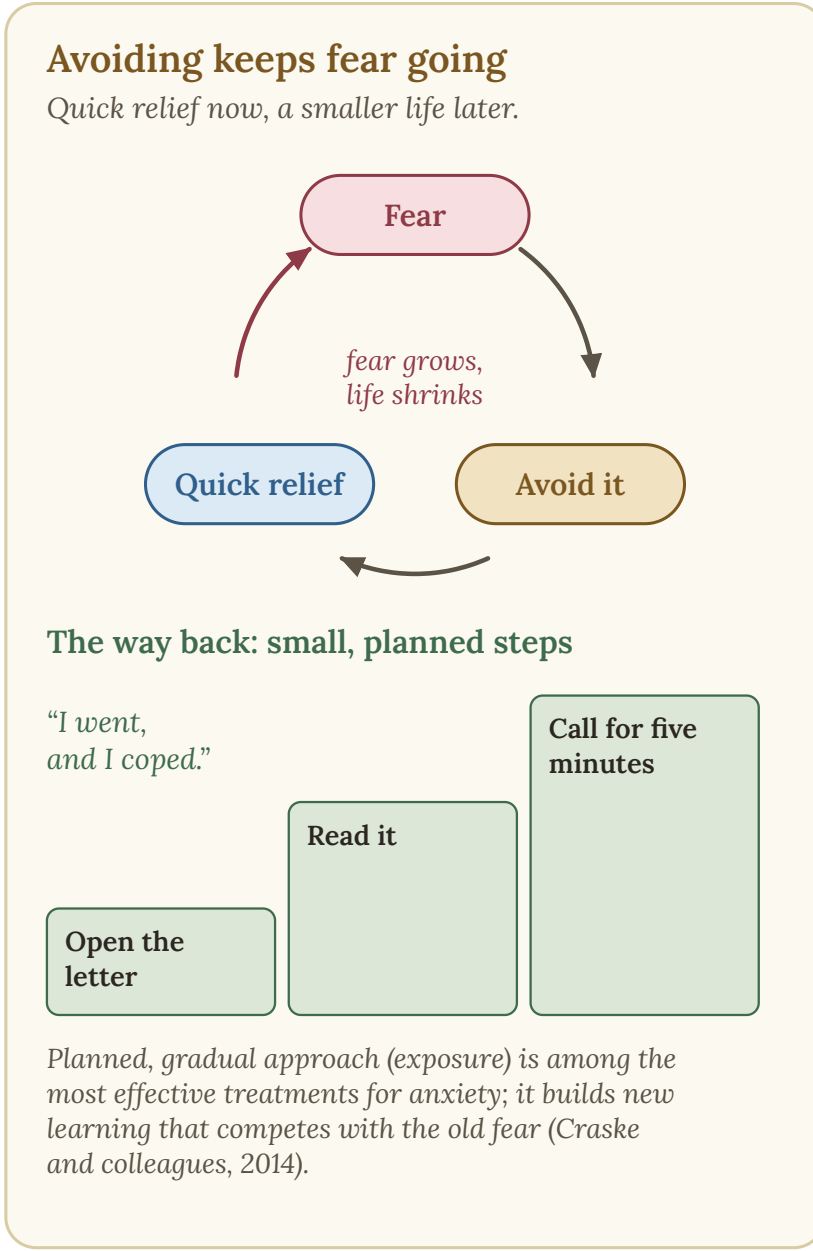



FIGURE 4 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most.

03

## Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps a lot of people is postponing it. You notice a worry, write it down, and save it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practiced this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, go through the list and ask of each one whether there's anything you can do about it. If there is, plan one step. If there isn't, practice letting it go, which is easier said than done, I know.

Desmond looks after his dad and keeps a small red notebook by the kettle. Worries go in it all day. At six, with a cup of tea, he gives the notebook fifteen minutes. By then half the morning's worries look smaller, and a couple have quietly worked themselves out. The one about the water heater has been in there since August, and he has decided to let it stay. When one turns up at the wrong time of day, the trick is to tell it, more or less, "Noted. I'll think about that at six."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

**Flip it**

*Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam*

### Flip it

What's on your mind?

*What if I fail my biology exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?*

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · (A *worry*) · Being hard on myself · Anger

THE FLIP

**The best outcome would be**
[what you hope for]

**The main thing in the way**
I fail my biology exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

**If that happens, I'll**
[one small thing you could do]

**One step today**
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version

*Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.*

When the worry comes back at 1am

*It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.*

*If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust.*

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Small wins: Flip it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

## Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a let-down is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, appetite changes, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness. It can also look like irritability, or just running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

Lionel taught geography for thirty-one years. Lately he has stopped going to the Thursday walking group. He isn't reading. He wakes at four every morning and lies there listening to the water heater come on. Getting old, he tells himself. It was his daughter, up for the weekend, who said it, carefully, while they were doing the dishes. "Dad, I think this might be depression. And that can be treated." He was pretty annoyed with her for about a day.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness." "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

05

## Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood tells you to wait until you feel like it. But withdrawing makes life emptier, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioral activation turns this around. You plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure or a sense of having done something, and you do them whether you feel like it

or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

After her divorce, living on her own, Lorraine planned three small things a day, a ten-minute walk to the postbox and back, one call or message, and one job she could finish, like wiping the stove. Most days, honestly, they felt pointless. She did them anyway, and over a few weeks the days started to feel less dull, though she couldn't tell you which day it changed.

06

### Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter. The evidence is solid all the same. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups protects as well. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

A new dad, exhausted and low, sat down with his partner and a calendar and between them they blocked out one protected long sleep each on the weekend, a stroller walk every morning around the park whatever the weather, and his old Wednesday five-a-side, which he'd dropped when the baby came and missed

**People are not an optional extra**

A meta-analysis of 148 studies, with over 300,000 people, found that people with stronger social ties had about 50% better odds of survival over the years they were followed. The studies observe rather than prove cause, but it's hard to read that and call calling a friend a luxury.

**Holt-Lunstad, Smith and Layton (2010)** · *Strong: a large meta-analysis of observational studies; cause not established*

more than he'd admitted. He was terrible at five-a-side the first week, and went back anyway. Calm sounds help some people wind down at night, too, and Cool-down corner has some.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

## Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

Months after a crash at a wet intersection, Shirin still jumps at the sound of brakes and won't drive after dark. Her partner has started saying "It's fine, it's fine" before she's even flinched, which she finds both sweet and maddening. Her alarm learned that cars can

mean danger and hasn't unlearned it yet. That is a long way from overreacting. Trauma-focused therapies help many people.

08

## After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. A review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first, and the same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

Someone had been in Grandma's house while she was at the store. They took her purse from the drawer and her late husband's watch. She didn't want to talk about it, and said so, twice. Her grandson didn't push. He fixed the lock on the back door, which took him most of the afternoon and two trips to the hardware shop, and slept on her sofa. "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here," he said in the morning, and went to work. A week later she called him at nine at night and talked for an hour, mostly about the watch.

09

## Therapy helps many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It's one of the most studied talk therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioral activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Medicines work differently for different people, and stopping one suddenly can cause problems of its own.

Zack was too embarrassed to ask anyone about the panic attacks. Then one kept him from getting on the 7:40 for the second week in a row, and he stood on the platform watching it go. His doctor referred him for a short course of CBT, eight sessions. He takes the train to work again now, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days, and there are still some bad days. Before an appointment, it helps to write three lines, on what you've noticed, how long it has gone on, and what it's stopping you doing.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while."
> "What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back toward life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

*Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope from the gas board and told them, out loud, feeling ridiculous, that they could wait till morning. You slept a bit. Now you breathe out long at the kitchen window and text your neighbor. Hospital at ten and I'm a bit scared, cup of coffee after?*

*Three hearts and "course." The appointment is still the appointment. You look at the envelope again, and the weeks of not wanting to see anyone, and add a fourth line at the bottom, smaller than the others. Ask about my mood.*

## If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all land at once, usually at about one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep the night before her biology exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step (ask Mr. Okafor what kind of questions come up) and puts her phone out on the landing, which she hates. The next day she tells her mom, who says, "Why didn't you wake me?" and it helps more than Tolu expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust.

YOU COULD SAY

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Asking for reassurance again and again

FROM OUTSIDE "Are you sure you're not angry with me?" for the fourth time tonight.

THE LOGIC Doubt feels like danger. Reassurance turns the alarm off for a moment. Then the alarm comes back. Asking again is trying to turn it off again.

IT'S LIKE Going back to check the front door is locked.

WHY IT FITS Uncertainty can feel unbearable when you're anxious, and asking brings real relief, even if it is brief.

THE OTHER SIDE Answering again and again is tiring, and it can keep the loop going.

YOU COULD SAY "*My worry keeps coming back. Asking turns it down for a bit.*"

ONE SMALL STEP Agree a kind limit together. One clear answer, then something calming to do side by side.

---

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people worry out loud, talking it round until it shrinks. Others keep it in, and talking about it too soon makes it grow. If you talk it out, the quiet worrier may need a walk side by side more than a conversation. If you keep it in, the talker isn't making a fuss. Saying it is how they get it out of their head.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Holistic therapies start with the body, which is where worry lives first: slow breathing out, a walk, a regular bedtime. Some of these practices are well studied and some are debated. Aromatherapy adds that the setting matters, a quieter room or softer light. The evidence for particular oils is weak, so the help here is the room, not the bottle.

---

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=reassurance

## In everyday life

Living on your own can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day is worth protecting, even a two-minute call (see On your own: when it's lonely, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, low

mood can look like not caring, and anxiety can look like nagging when it's really a worried mind asking again for reassurance. Describe what's going on instead of leaving the other person to guess: "I'm low today, and I'm not mad at you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on a loop. A friend who keeps canceling may be struggling. Keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 4 (page 65) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a short honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, so make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On your own: when it's lonely
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

## Common mix-ups

Anxiety doesn't mean something is wrong with you. It's a normal alarm. It only becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life. Depression isn't just sadness, and nobody snaps out of it. It affects sleep, energy, thinking and the body as well as mood, and many people recover with the right help. Not everything bad that happens is trauma in the clinical

sense, which usually means a threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair. Talking about trauma right away doesn't help everyone either. Some people want to and some don't, forcing it can make things worse, and safety and choice come first.

## If you want to help someone else with this

Notice, and ask. "You've seemed a bit low lately. How are you doing, really?" opens the door, and after that it helps to listen more than you talk. Don't argue with the feeling. "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away. "That sounds really hard" keeps them close. Offer something specific, a walk or a meal or a ride somewhere, because a small practical offer is much easier to accept than a big vague one.

If you're worried someone may be thinking of ending their life, it's okay to ask them plainly, in your own words. Asking doesn't put the idea in their head (a review by Dazzi and colleagues, 2014, found no sign that it does). If they say yes, stay with them, listen, and help them tell someone else they trust. And look after yourself too, because supporting someone who is struggling is tiring (see Book 3, Chapter 7, page 113).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here."
> "Would it help if I came with you?"

**Workpapers** **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today: a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

## More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life
- For teens · For parents · New parents
- Caring for someone you love
- At work
- **Related chapters:** Stress (Chapter 1, page 7) · Self-worth and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 79) · Healing (Chapter 5, page 81)
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On your own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

## THIS CONNECTS TO


**Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system** — page 7
*The stress ladder and rest*

**Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 79
*A kinder inner voice*

**Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well** — Understanding Each Other, page 113
*Supporting someone who is struggling*

**Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 25
*Checking your weather each day*


## PUT IT TO USE

**The Calm-Down Kit**
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

**Cool-down corner: Upset right now?**
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth

# 4

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 4

# Loss, grief and big life changes

*What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

*Six months on, you're doing fine, or that's what you tell people, and on most days it's even true.*

*Then, in aisle seven, there's the cereal, his cereal, the faded blue box he always said tasted of cardboard and ate every single morning for thirty years. You leave the cart where it is, next to the oatmeal, and walk out to the car and sit in it with the engine off. A woman loading her trunk two spaces down glances over and then, kindly, doesn't.*

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something. It might be a person, or a pet, or a marriage or a friendship, their health or a home or a job, a country they had to leave or a future they'd pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There's no right way to grieve. Nothing here is a schedule, and if any of it doesn't fit you, leave it.

Aisle seven, in quick strokes. On the surface, a box of cereal. Underneath, six months of being fine. Underneath that, love with nowhere to go. The roots are balance and state and setting, what was given and is now missing, and where the wave happens to land. The chapter goes through them slowly.

01

## Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted off, children leaving home. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever anyone else thinks the loss ought to mean.

When Bramble died, his owner was shaken by how hard he took it, and his friends at the bar told him, kindly enough, that it was only

a dog. That dog walked beside him along the same stretch of river every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce. The lead is still on its hook by the back door, and he can't move it yet.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you've never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship." "I'm grieving the life we planned." They're small sentences, and they can bring a surprising amount of relief.

02

## Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone goes through in order. Most people swing back and forth, some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and researchers who study grief see that swing as healthy.

Three months after Gerald died, Val laughed properly at lunch. Her sister had told a story about a man at the bowls club and a wasp, and Val laughed till she had to put her fork down. On the bus home she felt terrible about it. That evening she cried for two hours. The lunch was grief too, and so was the bus.

**Back and forth is normal**

The dual process model describes healthy grief as moving back and forth between facing the loss and getting on with life, with breaks from grief included. In this model Val's laugh at lunch isn't a lapse. It's part of the grieving.

**Stroebe and Schut (1999)** · *Moderate: a widely used framework with partial support*

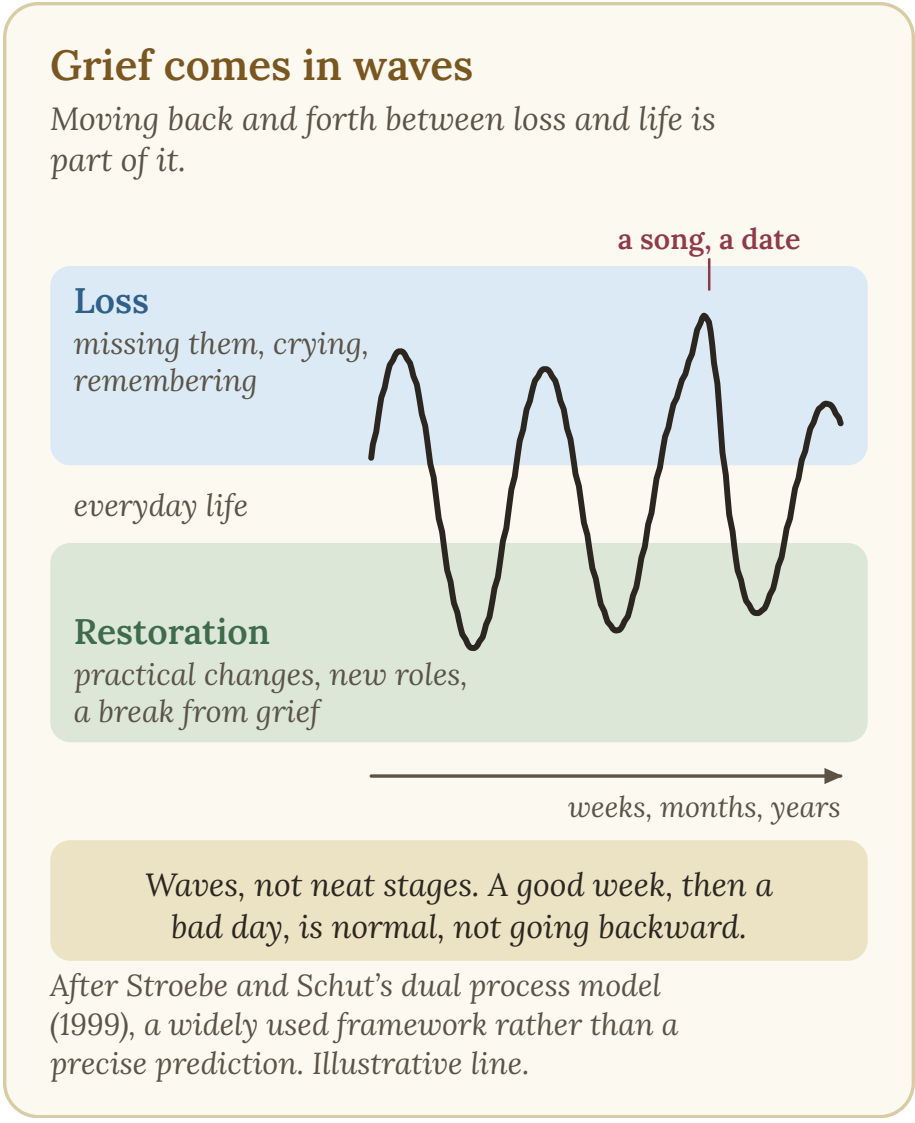



FIGURE 5 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

### Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, bad sleep, no appetite or too much, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there

has gone, and the learning takes time and uses a lot of energy.

An assistant principal whose mother has just died loses her car keys three times in one week. She drives to school on a Saturday, and walks into a school board meeting that is happening on Thursday when it is in fact Tuesday. She starts to wonder, quietly, if something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog. It lifts as the months go on, though nobody can tell her when, and she'd really like somebody to.

While it lasts, look after a few basics, like one real meal a day and a regular bedtime and a short walk outside, and it's fine to tell people, "I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

04

## Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed by dementia or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Other losses go unrecognized, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online.

Every Sunday at two, Teresa visits her dad at the nursing home. He's always pleased to see her. He thinks she's his sister, Connie, and asks after their mother, who died in 1987. Teresa has stopped correcting him, and they talk about Connie's life, which Teresa now knows a surprising amount about. She is grieving someone who hasn't died.

**A loss without an ending**

Pauline Boss named this ambiguous loss: someone gone but still present in the mind, or present but changed, as with dementia. Part of what makes it so hard is that there's no clear ending to grieve.

**Boss (1999)** · *Moderate: a widely used framework, backed by clinical and interview research*

There's no funeral for that, no cards, and at work nobody thinks to ask.

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one, a candle or a letter or a bulb in the yard, or just going to stand for a while somewhere that mattered.

05

### People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying. Others grieve by doing, fixing things, organizing, working, building. Neither is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't grieving, when they're grieving differently, and culture and faith and age and how your mind works all shape how it comes out.

After their son died, Janet wanted to talk about him every evening. Steve went into the garage every weekend and worked on the old Raleigh that Ryan had never got around to fixing. She thought he was hiding. He thought she was making it worse. It took a bereavement counselor about forty minutes to point out, gently, that they were both doing exactly the same thing. In March Steve brought the bike out, finished. Janet cried and he let her. Then she asked him what was wrong with the gears, and he told her, for some time.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

**Write it through**

*Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter*

## Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Roommate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
*Malcolm and Fiona*

Your name (optional)
*Mom*

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
*How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.*

How I feel about it

*tired* · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
*Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll call you if I need you in between?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
*I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Fiona called the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.*

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

## You don't have to let go.

An older idea said healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and the values they carry on, so the relationship changes shape without having to end.

Ama wears her grandpa's watch to every exam. It's far too big. She has to push it up her arm to write. She doesn't believe in luck, and if you asked her why she does it she would probably shrug and say "dunno," but the honest answer is that it feels as if he's in the room.

You could pick one way of keeping a bond, cooking their recipe, or telling one of their stories at Christmas, or keeping one of their habits going. Some people find it helps, in a hard moment, to ask what the person would have said. Often it's something rude.

**Continuing bonds**
This is the book that challenged the cut-the-ties view of mourning, showing that inner bonds with someone who has died are common across many groups and often healthy. Later research adds a fair caveat: for some people the bond comforts, and for others it hurts.

**Klass, Silverman and Nickman (1996)** · *Moderate: influential; effects differ from person to person*

07

## Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retiring, moving country, a child starting school, coming out, getting well after a long illness. All of them can bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing middle bit, and a new beginning. The middle is the hardest part and also the easiest to rush.

Ifeoma and Olu moved to Denver for a job they both wanted. They toasted it with fizz in the empty apartment. Six months in, Olu felt low, and then guilty for feeling low, since this was the plan. What nobody had toasted was what they'd left behind, a circle of friends, a café where nobody had to ask what they wanted, and a whole Saturday that used to run itself. You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a loss is hard to talk about, writing can come first. Put the words down at your own pace. You never have to send them.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/write-it-through

08

## Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that over time many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, though they never forget. Being around people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it.

A year after his wife died, Dennis still couldn't go into their bedroom. He slept on the couch and had stopped answering his friends' calls. His doctor referred him to a grief counselor and he went, mainly so his daughter would stop asking. Things moved, slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's, watching the snooker and not saying much. He's back in the bedroom now, on his own side of the bed.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Your wiring, weather and words (Book 1, Chapter 2, page 25)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

*You let it come, for ten minutes maybe, and then you blow your nose on a napkin from the glove box and go back in. The cart is still there by the oatmeal, and you put the cereal in it, without knowing why.*

*At home you text your sister. Saw Dad's cereal. Cried in the parking lot. She's typing right away. Same thing happened to me with his aftershave in the drugstore. Call tonight?*

## Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, in the empty chair and the jobs that were always theirs and the paperwork, done alone, and in the first birthday and the first anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time, and let one drawer count as a day's work. It's fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill out the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you've lost a partner, and you may grieve on different clocks. If they start calling every day, that comes from love and worry. It isn't control, and you can still say what helps. "I love that you call. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll call you if I need you?"

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Grief, read two ways

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people grieve by talking, crying and remembering out loud. Others grieve by doing, mending, fixing the bike. If you talk, the doer may look as if they've moved on. Usually they haven't, and the doing is the grief. If you do, the talker isn't wallowing. Telling the story again is how they carry it.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Philosophy has asked for a long time what makes a life go well, and part of its answer is that the people we lose stay part of it. Laughter, oddly, belongs here too: a shared laugh can tell a grieving body it's safe for a minute. The research on laughter is still young, so read that as a small comfort.

## In everyday life

After a miscarriage one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and cry at bedtime, and both are grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is usually stuck for words more than cold. Colleagues who avoid the subject when someone comes back after a death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been rubbed out. And a whole town can grieve together, when it loses its library or its factory.

### On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people around you. When you're carrying it on your own, give the day a small shape, with a meal and a walk in it and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help, and nobody ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is enough of a goal.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening may help.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Grief and later life · For a hard evening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

## If you want to help someone else with this

Show up, and then keep showing up. Support floods in for about two weeks and then stops, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal. Offer something specific, because "Can I drop dinner round on Thursday?" is far easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything." Say the name, too. Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear it, and a memory with it, and if you're not sure, ask. Leave out the explanations, since "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt. "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does. And if you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss, not the ones closest to it. Comfort goes in toward the middle and venting goes out.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mom today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

**Tools** **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? for a wave that feels too big

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/upset-right-now

## More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family · Family rifts after a loss or a will
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve · For teens
- **Big changes:** Empty nest · Retired together · Coming home after time apart · New parent
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is sick or disabled · Caring for someone you love
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 79) · Minds that work differently (Book 1, Chapter 7, page 115)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
Grief and family · Helping children grieve
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
Family rifts after a loss or a will
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest



ONLINE
Retired together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together



ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
New parent
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent



ONLINE
When one of you is sick or disabled
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging**
*Why losing a bond hurts so much*
Understanding Each Other, page 61

**Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well**
*Supporting someone who is grieving*
Understanding Each Other, page 113

**Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma**
*When grief turns into low mood*
page 45

**Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from**
*Losses that shaped your lens*
Know Yourself Kindly, page 7

PUT IT TO USE

**Cool-down corner: Upset right now?**
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

**Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music**
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss-in-depth

# 5

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 5

# Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness and old hurts

*How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, and what forgiveness is and isn't.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. How old hurts shape new reactions
11. In everyday life
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.
- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.

- **Going back is a choice.** You can heal even if they never say sorry.

THURSDAY, 2AM

*It was one sentence, three weeks ago, said over your shoulder in somebody's kitchen at a party on the way to the fridge, and they have almost certainly forgotten it.*

*You haven't. It plays again, word for word, tone and all, followed by every clever thing you could have said back and didn't. You're very tired of carrying it about, and you honestly don't know where you'd put it down if you could.*

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works and how relationships mend, and at how you can heal with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones.

Seen fast, a sentence from three weeks ago is three things. On top, the words, which you can still quote. Under them, what they seemed to say about you. Under that, the question of whether it will happen again. The roots are balance and signal and noise. The chapter slows down on repair.

01

## Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether it was the person, or your trust in them, or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them and keep you safe from the next one. Healing rarely goes in a straight line. The hurt can come back on an anniversary, or out of nowhere, which doesn't mean you've failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel to him at a party, Kwesi still feels a jolt whenever the song that was playing comes on the radio. It happened again on Sunday, chopping onions. He said, out loud, to nobody, "Oh, that," turned the radio down, and carried on with the onions.

**What a hurt is about**

When Leary and colleagues asked people about times their feelings were hurt, the common thread was feeling less valued by someone, usually someone they knew well. A stranger's remark stings for an afternoon. A friend's can stay for months.

**Leary and colleagues (1998)** · *Moderate: based on people's recollections; the idea is widely supported*

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

02

## Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time, because people snap, forget, misread each other and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way. Breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than before the break.

Orange juice, a full glass, right across the breakfast table and into the toast rack. Toby's dad shouted, not a huge shout, but enough. Twenty minutes later he sat down next to him on the couch. "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair, spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?" They went and did it together. Toby poured, very slowly, with his tongue out, and slopped some, and they both pretended he hadn't.

**Even therapy has ruptures**

Across 11 studies, repairing breaks in the relationship between therapist and client went with better results. Training therapists in repair didn't show a clear effect on outcomes in the six studies that tested it, which is a useful bit of honesty.

**Eubanks, Muran and Safran (2018)** · *Strong: a meta-analysis, though the main finding is correlational*

03

## Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance. It works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, and leave out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of a fight.

Amara had a stronger word ready, one she'd been working on for days. On a walk with her friend, not over the phone, she said this instead. "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." Her friend, who had honestly thought she was helping, went bright red. There was a long, awful pause next to a bench with a brass plaque on it for somebody called Maud. Then the friend said, "God. Yes. Sorry," and they walked on. It was a bit stiff for the rest of the walk and fine by the following week.

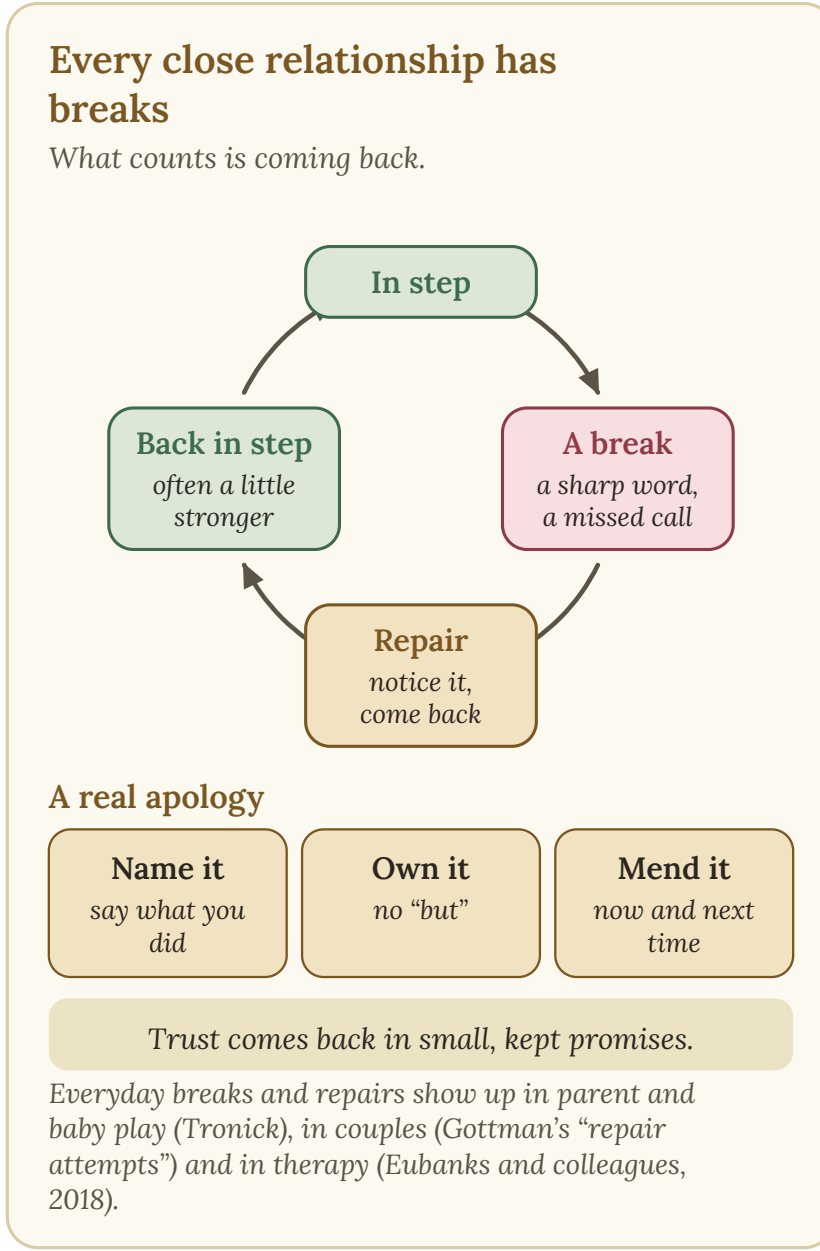



FIGURE 6 Every close relationship has breaks. What counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

Before you say it, try writing it down in three short lines, one for what happened, one for how you felt and one for what you'd like.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

**Write it through**

*Carys, writing to her brother Owen*

## Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Roommate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)

*Owen*

Your name (optional)

*Carys*

What kind of message?

*Raise something* · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

*At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.*

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

*Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?*

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

*I'm not angry with you as a person.*

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

*Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.*

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

04

## A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand what it did to the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

At the Tuesday meeting, Leila presented an idea she'd worked out with a colleague as if it were all hers. She saw his face. She spent the evening telling herself it didn't matter, then the next morning went and found him at the coffee machine. "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it

was joint work." He said, "Okay," and then, after a moment, "Thanks." She sent the email at 9.40 and copied him in.

Next time you say sorry, check it has each of the four parts. If it went wrong in a conversation, Rewind the talk helps you find the words, and Apology languages has more.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder



ONLINE
Apology languages
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

05

## Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying what happened was okay. It doesn't mean forgetting, or trusting them again, or keeping them in your life. It's a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on anyone else's schedule.

Danielle forgave her father for missing most of her childhood, though it took her well into her thirties. She keeps his visits to an hour and won't leave the children with him if he's been drinking. He knows why. They don't discuss it. For her the forgiving and the protecting sit side by side without much strain.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

06

## You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck for years, because the person may be gone, or unwilling, or unable to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe, and decide what it means for you now.

After the breakup, Martha wrote a letter she never sent. Four pages in pen, both sides, about what hurt and what she'd hoped for and what she was taking with her, which was mostly the good saucepans. She folded it into the back of a notebook and for a while she read it most nights, then less, and then one day in April she realized she hadn't looked at it for a month.

**Writing helps, a bit**

Pooling 146 randomized studies, Frattaroli found that writing about something painful had a small but real benefit on average. Small is the honest word, and it varies a good deal from person to person.

**Frattaroli (2006)** · *Moderate: a real but small effect that varies by person*

Writing works for a lot of people. Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes on three or four days in a row, the facts and the feelings both. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop and talk to someone instead.

07

## Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in lots of small moments where someone does what they said they'd do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture. If you were let down, it's fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner for most of a year. When it came out it was very bad for a while. After that, on the first of every month, he left his bank statement on the kitchen table without being asked, with no speech, just the statement left by the fruit bowl. About a year in, one ordinary evening, his partner said she could breathe again. He went into the yard so she wouldn't see his face.

08

## Going back is a choice.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship or change its shape. You can also step away. All three can be healthy.

Ellie's roommate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go, because it was only ten dollars and she'd been broke herself. The second time it was fifty dollars for a train ticket to Chicago, and she said, "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get along in the house." The roommate went quiet for two days and left a slightly pointed note about the recycling. They still do Sunday dinner together most weeks, and nobody mentions Chicago.

Three questions can guide what comes next. Has the hurt stopped? Has it been owned? Do you want this relationship in your life?

It also helps to tell one hurt from a pattern of hurt. A single hurt, owned and repaired, is something most relationships survive, and many come out closer. A pattern looks different. The same hurt keeps happening after you've named it, apologies arrive without any change, and you notice yourself saying less to avoid the next one. One bad month isn't a pattern, and neither is a partner who is slow to apologize but changes what they do.

09

## Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep or a jumpy feeling that won't settle. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest and food and moving about, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful and some don't, and neither is a test you can fail.

A man at the back of the 38 bus shouted at Idris and called him names, the whole way from Angel to Dalston, and nobody else said a word. For days afterward Idris felt shaky. He told a friend. He went for long walks after work. He kept reminding himself it was about the man, and that he was safe now. Over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded, though he sat downstairs on the 38 until well into the spring.

Pick one small act of care for today, an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now?

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/upset-right-now

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologize for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologize or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

*You wrote it all down last night, every word of it, two pages. This morning you wrote a much shorter version. When you said that, I felt small. I just wanted you to know.*

*You haven't sent it. It's sitting in your drafts between a half-finished email to the city about trash pickup and a shopping list that just says "eggs??" But the two o'clock replays have gone a bit quieter since it went onto paper.*

## How old hurts shape new reactions

What happened earlier in life can make some reactions more likely now. In surveys of tens of thousands of adults in 24 countries, most had lived through at least one traumatic event (Kessler and colleagues, 2017 · Strong evidence), and many studies have linked hard childhood experiences with health and relationship problems decades later (Felitti and colleagues, 1998 · Strong evidence). That is an association across large groups, not a forecast for any one person. A mark can be left at any age.

- In early childhood, a child who learned to watch a parent's mood may grow into an adult who scans every face in a meeting.

- In the school years, being shamed in front of a class can make any public correction sting.
- In the teens, months of being left out can make a group chat that goes quiet feel like a verdict.
- In early adulthood, a first job or first home that went badly can make the next change feel dangerous.
- In a partnership, a betrayal can make an innocent late text feel like the start of another one.
- As a parent, a frightening birth or a child's illness can leave you braced for the next emergency.
- In midlife, a layoff, a divorce or caring for a parent can wear down the reserves that used to absorb a bad day.
- In later life, losses and illness can arrive close together, with less time to recover between them.

Most people who go through something terrible recover without lasting problems (Bonanno, 2004 · Strong evidence). For some, especially after repeated or very severe events, the body's alarm stays switched on. Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) is the clinical name for one form of this. It follows exposure to actual or threatened death, serious injury or sexual violence, and most people who go through such events don't develop it (Koenen and colleagues, 2017 · Strong evidence). Trauma responses can look like being on edge, startling easily, avoiding reminders, going numb, or meeting a small thing with the force of the old one. Those responses once helped someone get through. In a conversation they usually make things harder, because the person is answering the past as well as the present.

You might recognize it in yourself when a reaction feels older than the moment, arrives in your body before you can think, follows the same kind of trigger each time, or is hard to explain afterward. You

might notice it in someone else when their reaction is far bigger than what just happened. These signs are for understanding. They are not a diagnosis, and you can't diagnose yourself or anyone else from them.

Having lived through something hard is never the person's fault. The aim is to take back control, so the old event stops running today's reaction. That usually starts small: noticing "this feels older than today," naming it, steadying your body, and then choosing what to do next. Trauma-focused therapies have the strongest evidence for PTSD (NICE, 2018 · Strong evidence).

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Fine all day, falling apart at home

FROM OUTSIDE At work or school they're fine. At home they melt down or go silent.

THE LOGIC Fitting in all day takes effort that doesn't show. The effort is held in until it is safe to stop. Home feels safe, so the holding lets go. The crash shows that home is trusted.

IT'S LIKE Holding your breath underwater and gasping at the surface.

WHY IT FITS Autistic adults describe "camouflaging" followed by exhaustion, and many other people do a version of it too.

THE OTHER SIDE The family gets the hardest part of the day.

YOU COULD SAY *"I hold it together all day. Home is where I can stop."*

ONE SMALL STEP A quiet half hour after getting home, with no questions. Later, a line like "That wasn't about you" helps.

---

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people show how they feel as they go, so a hard day shows during the day. Others hold it together for hours, at work or school, and let go only once they're somewhere safe, which is often home. If you show it as you go, the person who falls apart at home isn't saving their worst for you. Home is where it's safe to stop holding on. If you're the one who holds it in, saying "I've used it all up today" helps the people at home read the crash for what it is.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Finance gives repair a plain picture: a real apology tops up a reserve of goodwill that small hurts draw down. Psychology adds the reason repairs are needed even between kind people, that intent isn't impact.

---

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=mask-crash

## In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong, can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologize so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you

something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months. More in the full chapter.
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
How to apologize so it counts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

## If you want to help someone else with this

Listen before you advise. "That sounds really painful" helps far more than "You should just let it go." Don't rush them toward forgiveness, which can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter. Don't push them to cut someone off, either; it's their relationship and their choice. If you were the one who caused the hurt, give a real apology and then give them time, and don't ask them to make you feel better about it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

## More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts · For grown-up children
- **After a breakup:** On my own · Co-parenting
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Adult siblings and family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
Foster, adoptive and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

**Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair**
*Covering kindly and saying it out loud*
Share the Load, page 73

**Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works**
*Repair in everyday talk*
Understanding Each Other, page 23

**Chapter 2 · Anger**
*When anger did the damage*
page 27

**Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion**
*Guilt without shame*
Know Yourself Kindly, page 79

PUT IT TO USE



**Cool-down corner: Upset right now?**
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



**Apology languages**
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth

# 6

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 6

# Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

*Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation


MONDAY, 7:05AM

*The plan was a walk before work. The sneakers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7:40 you are watching a man in Finland restore a rusty axe, next to a coffee that went cold twenty minutes ago. You don't even like axes.*

*By the evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything. What you actually ran into this morning was a habit with about six years of practice behind it. It won, as it usually does for the first few rounds.*

This chapter is why several tools in these books are so small. One small step a week (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 45) starts smaller than feels useful and decides ahead of time. The setup score and One owner per job (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) change the setup instead of asking anyone for more willpower. And What keeps coming back? (Book 4, Chapter 5, page 97) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are an ordinary part of changing anything.

Quickly: a phone in your hand at 7:40 is the surface. Underneath, a habit with years of practice behind it. Underneath that, a setup that quietly makes the old way easier. The roots are feedback loops and quiet incentives. Then the chapter slows down and takes them one by one.

01

## Change is hard for good reasons.

A lot of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, and it's the whole point of a habit. The catch is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so changing asks your brain to do something effortful again and again, for weeks, until the new way becomes the easy one.

Every night Jodie decides she will not snap at the children in the morning, and she means it. Every morning, somewhere between the lost reading book and the toast going cold and Lily's hair, she snaps. The morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions, which says something about mornings and not much about her as a mother.

Pick one thing you'd like to change, and write down when it usually happens, where, and what's going on just before.

02

## Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger, which might be a time or a place or a feeling or a person, or simply the thing you've just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a small buzz) keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

Nigel noticed, eventually, that he reached for the cookie jar the moment he opened his laptop after dinner, hungry or not, every night, and the laptop was the cue. So now he makes tea before he opens it and makes a pot. By the time the tea's brewed the urge has mostly wandered off. On Fridays it doesn't wander anywhere and he has a custard cream, and that seems fair.

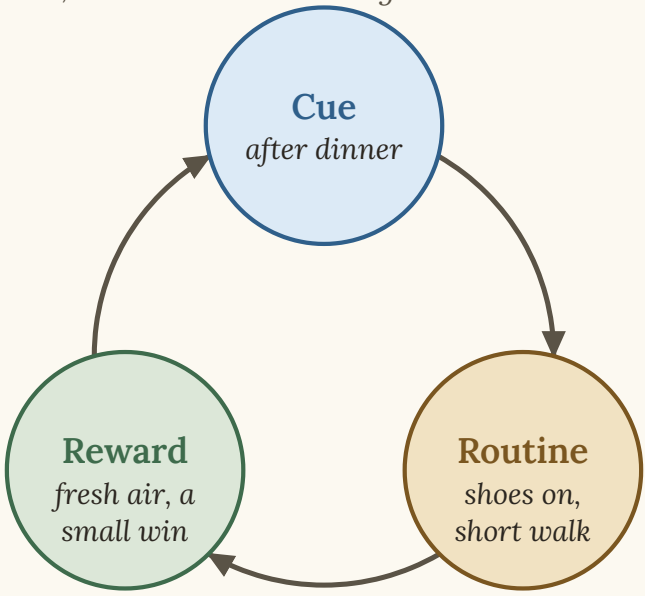
**Stale popcorn**

In one field experiment, people with a strong movie-popcorn habit ate stale popcorn about as much as fresh, but only in a movie theater. Somewhere else, they didn't. The setting drove the habit more than taste or good intentions did, rather like Nigel's laptop.

**Neal and colleagues (2011)** · *Moderate: two field experiments, in line with wider habit research*

## Habits run on cues

*Over time, the cue alone is enough.*




**Change the setup, not just your willpower:** *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

*The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).*

FIGURE 7 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

## Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring and easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work precisely because they're easy enough to manage on a bad day. Tie the new step to something you already do ("After I make my coffee, I'll…"), and only grow it once it's stuck.

Two roommates had been promising each other a big Sunday clean of the kitchen since March. It had happened once, so they agreed something smaller. After dinner, each of them wipes one surface, which takes two minutes. By the second week the stove had stopped being a source of tension. By the fourth, someone had descaled the kettle without being asked, which caused a small sensation.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I …, I will …"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

**Your done list**

*Bernie, 71, living on his own*

### Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

*Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe*

Who it was with

*With a friend*

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Called my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the mailroom instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

*A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.*

Fill in your own: Your done list

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE

Your done list

spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

## Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when you're tired or hungry. Your surroundings stay the same all day. So make the new habit easier, by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder, by moving it out of reach. I'd back a small change to the setup over a big push of effort almost every time. At home that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

Callan is seventeen and wants to sleep better, and for weeks he tried to stop scrolling in bed by sheer force of will. It didn't work once. Then his mom suggested charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, next to the bread box. He said this was ridiculous, and did it anyway, mainly to prove her wrong, and within a week he

was asleep before midnight most nights. Every few weeks he tells her it's ridiculous, without much conviction.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER
WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

**Willpower isn't a fuel tank, probably**

A popular idea says self-control runs out like fuel. When 23 labs tried to repeat the classic experiment together, they found an effect close to zero. The argument isn't over, but it's one more reason to change the setup rather than lean harder on yourself.

**Hagger and colleagues (2016)** · *Strong: a large pre-registered replication; the debate continues*

05

## Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn't, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, or protect you from something. Pushing harder against it rarely works, and listening to it often does.

Asif wanted to drink less, and he also loved Friday nights at the bar with his team. When he finally asked himself what Friday actually gave him, the answer wasn't really the beer. It was the people, the laughing, the end of the week. So he kept the Friday and switched to alcohol-free after the first pint. If anyone at the table noticed, they didn't say, which is its own sort of kindness.

Try two lists, one of what you like about how things are, one of what you'd like about changing. You're allowed both, and I suspect the first one will be the more honest of the two.

06

## Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo the progress. What does the damage is usually the thought that follows. "I've blown it, so why bother?" Being kind to yourself after a slip makes it a good deal more likely you'll start again.

Three calm weeks, and then Lewis shouted at his son over spellings. Really shouted, the old way. That night he sat on the end of the bed in the dark. "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." A small voice from under the duvet said "Okay." The next evening they did the spellings at the kitchen table with the radio on. Nobody raised their voice. The word was "necessary," which neither of them could spell.

**There's a name for "why bother?"**
Relapse-prevention research calls it the abstinence violation effect: after one slip, guilt and a sense of total failure make a full slide back more likely. It comes from addiction treatment, but the shape is the same for cookies and evening runs.

**Marlatt and Gordon (1985)** · *Moderate: a foundational clinical model, widely used in addiction treatment*

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

Decide now, while things are going well, what you'll do after a slip. Have one kind sentence to say to yourself and one small step to start again. A game can help some people practice, and the Re-check Drive turns small kind steps into calm football.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

## Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please someone, or out of shame, is hard to keep up. Change that connects to what you care about has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for the person you're turning into.

Rania kept meaning to be better at keeping in touch, and kept not being. What shifted it was a different sentence in her head. She stopped telling herself she must message people and started thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. A voice note on Sunday evenings became part of that. Some weeks it's thirty seconds of nonsense and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

08

## You can support change, but not force it.

It's natural to want the people we love to change, to drink less, or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, ask what would help, and notice their small steps out loud.

Grant kept missing deadlines, and his teammate had the lecture about being organized all ready, she'd been polishing it for two

weeks, and at the last minute she didn't give it. She asked what would make the handover easier, and he looked surprised. Between them they set up a shared checklist, and he fills it in every Friday before lunch, mostly. She has kept the lecture, though, in a note on her phone.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

*The sneakers are still by the door. The phone sleeps in the kitchen now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on, out to the end of the road. Some mornings that's all. Most mornings it turns into a loop past the community gardens and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it you'll get to the end of the road tomorrow. It says you won't. You do.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Change, two ways

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people love a fresh start and throw themselves at a new plan. Others need to change one small thing and see it hold first. If you're a fresh-starter, the slow one isn't lacking willpower. They're protecting what already works. If you're slow and steady, the fresh-starter isn't being reckless. Novelty is part of what keeps them going.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Behavioral science says habits beat good intentions, and business adds the simple check: one owner for a change and one small look each week at whether it held. The root is feedback loops, small things repeated with a check each time.

## In everyday life

Take a couple who want to spend less of the evening on their phones. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other. This time they put a basket by the door, both phones go in at nine, and there's one exception for whoever's on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward. On the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football. By the third week the basket is part of the furniture and the evenings have a shape again, a movie or a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, a move or a new baby, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears, and make the reward come right away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter.

### On your own: a kind plan for change

If you're working on something alone, the whole chapter fits into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it a cue, written as "After I ___, I will ___." Make one tweak to your surroundings so it's easier to start. Decide on the smallest version you could still manage on a tired day. And write down one kind sentence to use after a slip. The self path and Know yourself, next (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 45) walk through it step by step.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

## Common mix-ups

"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it" is the cruelest of these, and it's wrong. Wanting is only the start. Habits, setup, tiredness and stress all get a vote. Then there's the famous 21 days. There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range. Being hard on yourself doesn't keep you on track, either. Harshness makes people give up, and kindness makes it easier to try again. And routines don't have to mean being rigid. For a lot of people, autistic people especially, routines are what make life manageable, and change can respect that.

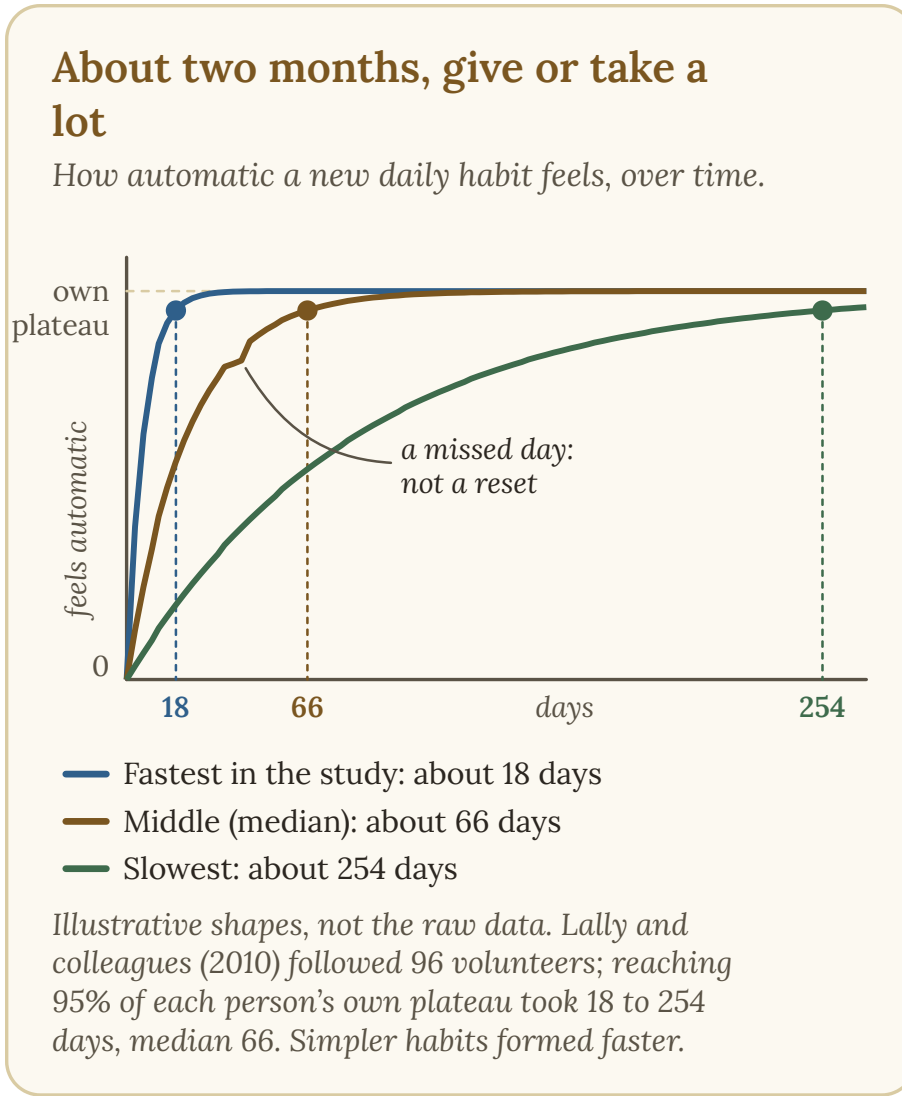



FIGURE 8 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

## If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise ("Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?"), and help them find their own reasons by asking

what would be different for them if this changed. Practical help with the setup, like a ride to the gym, often does more than encouragement. Notice small steps out loud and be kind about slips. Look after yourself too. You can care a great deal and still have limits on what you'll put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days in a row. That's not nothing."

## Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in, the quick checks and the self path can help you keep track.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13



ONLINE
quick checks
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks



ONLINE
the self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

## More for your situation

- On my own
- New parents
- When a child has ADHD
- Neurodivergent relationships
- Gaming, phones and time together

- At work
- Coming home after time apart
- Find it by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Gaming, phones and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
Find it by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- ✓ **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- ✓ **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- ✓ **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

THIS CONNECTS TO


**Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 45
*One small goal and tiny steps*

**Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back** — Share the Load, page 97
*The monthly look-back*

**Book 4, Chapter 2 · Is the split working?** — Share the Load, page 27
*Changing the setup, not the person*

**Book 1, Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 97
*How much people really change*


PUT IT TO USE



**Complacency**
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency`



**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth`

# 7

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 7

# Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

*What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.*

IN THIS CHAPTER


1. Values are directions you keep walking in
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. Tools and reading on this site
12. More for your situation


AT A GLANCE

- **Values are directions you keep turning toward.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.

- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

*The week ahead has the car inspection on Tuesday, a dentist, two late meetings and your turn for the school drop-off, twice, and none of it feels like yours, somehow. You're not sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, and not because it was next on the list.*

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology, and from philosophy, which has been asking how we ought to live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. I've tried to keep the old names to a minimum and the words plain.

In quick strokes, a full week looks like a diary problem. Underneath, it is a values problem, two good things wanting the same evening. Underneath that, what quietly gets rewarded at home. The roots are ownership and structure, and quiet incentives. The chapter then slows down on each.

01

## Values are directions you keep walking in.

A goal is something you can tick off, like painting the hall or passing the test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, like looking after your health, or making home feel cared for, or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind. That's exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan was going to go to the gym three times this week. She went once, on the Monday. On Thursday evening she was on the couch in her gym clothes eating a family bag of fries and feeling like a failure. So she asked herself what the gym was for. Looking after her body, was the answer, and when she asked what that was for, it was so she'd have energy for the kids. On Friday she walked twenty minutes at lunchtime, around the little park behind the office, past the man who feeds the pigeons, and as far as she was concerned it counted.

02

### Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from scratch. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness tends to show what you love.

A colleague stood up in the quarterly review and took credit for a whole team's work, and Sacha was so angry he couldn't eat his lunch. He spent the afternoon drafting emails he didn't send. On the train home it dawned on him that it wasn't really about the colleague. It was fairness. Seeing people's effort. That was what had been stepped on. At the next team meeting he raised it as a fairness thing ("Can we agree how we credit joint work?") instead of seething at one person for a month, and it went better than any of the emails would have.

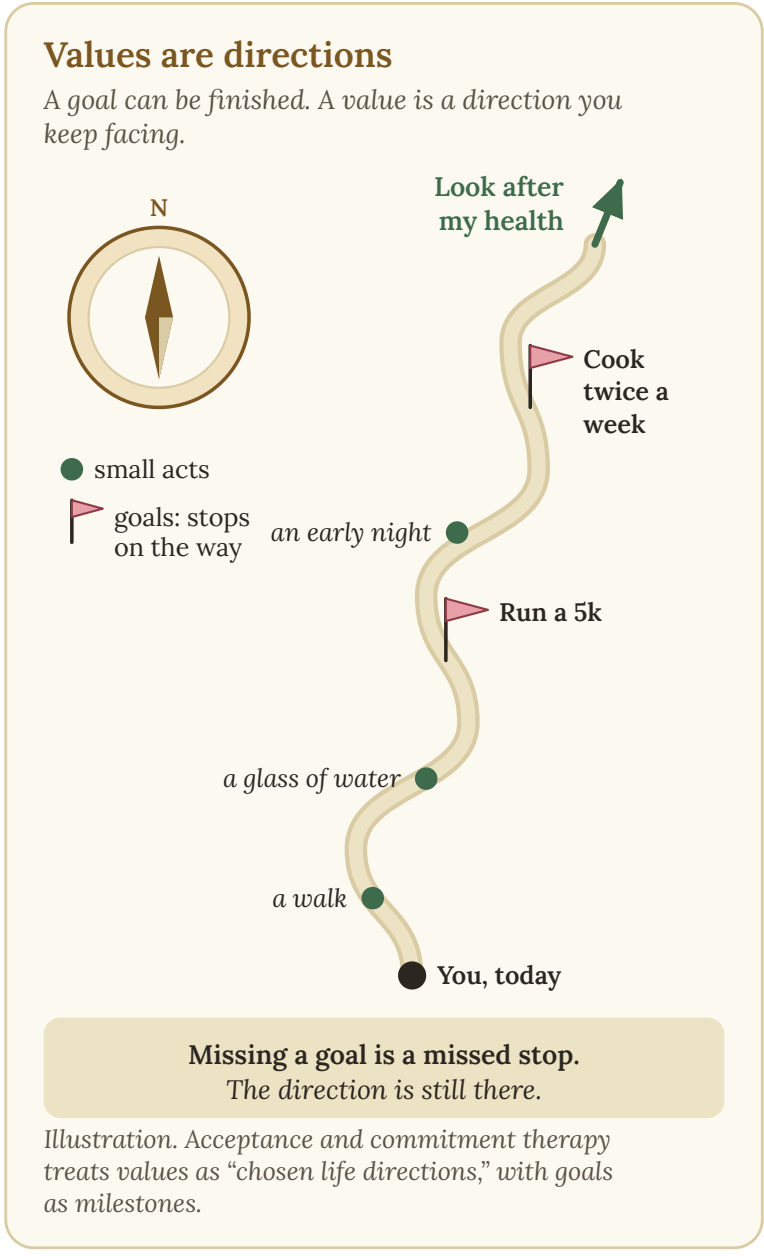



FIGURE 9 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way. Missing one doesn't change the direction.

03

## Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't between something good and something bad. They're between two good things, honesty and kindness, say, or family and rest. Feeling torn just means you care about more than one thing. Even when you choose well, it's normal to feel a bit sad about the side you didn't pick.

Pickles, the family Labrador, was very ill, and Megan's eight-year-old kept asking. Megan cares about being honest, and she also cares about protecting her son. She sat on the kitchen floor next to the dog's bed with him and tried to do both. "Pickles is very sick. The vet is helping. We'll look after him together." Her son thought about it for a long time, picking at the edge of the dog blanket. "Is he going to die?" "He might," she said. "We don't know yet." He put his hand on Pickles's side, very carefully, and left it there.

If you're stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. You may be able to honor some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

## Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. It's one of the oldest ideas in this book and still one of the most useful. Your own choices and how you treat people are up to you. Other people's choices, and the weather, and the past, are not. Worry tends to pile up in the second heap. Values do their work in the first.

Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas at her mom's, and she can't make him. She has tried, for six years, mainly by telling him it'll be fun. What she can do is plan a shorter visit, put a long

muddy walk on the day after Christmas into it, which he'll like, and be warm herself. That's her part, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

05

### A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. But many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists now, also describe a second kind of wellbeing. It comes from growing, using your strengths, being a decent friend, and doing things that matter even when they're hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought you build it the way you build any skill, by practice, a little at a time.

Jade spent a whole month of evenings helping a friend move out of a damp, miserable apartment. She scrubbed black mold off a bathroom ceiling with a toothbrush. She carried boxes down three flights of stairs while the friend cried on the landing. It was tiring and not much fun, and at the end of the year, when she thinks back over it, she counts it as one of the best months she had.

06

### Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it: your life makes some sense to you, you're heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles other people count on, far more than from big moments.

Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went very quiet. Now he reads to the under-fives at the library on Wednesday mornings. He irons a shirt for it on Tuesday nights. He does the voices, badly. When he had a cold in February and missed two weeks, a four-year-old called Albie asked the librarian every single day where the man was.

Try listing the roles you play, big or small (neighbor, sister, the one who waters the office plants), and next to each one write who it matters to.

**Three meanings of meaning**

The three parts above come from Martela and Steger, who split meaning into coherence (life makes sense), purpose (a direction) and significance (your life matters). It's a way of thinking that has shaped later research rather than a finding in itself.

**Martela and Steger (2016)** · *Theory: a conceptual paper that has shaped later measurement*

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

**Keep your little rituals alive**

*Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together*

## Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
*Lachlan*

Person B
*Sunita*

Date
*October 2, 2026*

### Part A: Our rituals, big and small

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Monday coffee call, cameras optional* | *Weekly* | *Fading* | *Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30* |
| *Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat* | *Weekly* | *Alive* | *Five minutes; people notice each other's work* |
| *A card and lunch when someone leaves* | *Now and then* | *Alive* | *People leave feeling thanked* |

| Ritual or habit | How often | How it's doing | What it gives us, or what got in the way |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Office day with lunch together* | *Monthly* | *Stopped* | *Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests* |
| *Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day* | *Daily* | *New idea* | *So nobody wonders who's around* |

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

**Your rituals**
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

**Fading or stopped**
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

**New ideas**
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

## Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
*Monday coffee call*

The smallest version that still counts
*Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional*

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
*Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite*

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
*A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.*

**Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks**

The ritual
*Office day with lunch together*

What it gave us
*A day all together, back when we all lived near the office*

*The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.*

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-15 · free to print
Keep your little rituals alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

07

## Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad.

People who love you will sometimes try to change your mind, and that's ordinary influence. They tell you why, they listen to your reasons, and the choice stays yours. It becomes pressure when it keeps coming after you've said no, when saying no costs you something, such as days of coldness, money or being left out, or when it's aimed at the people and things that matter most to you.

A good test is whether you can say "I see it differently" and still be treated warmly the next day.

Jasper likes a calm, tidy house. His roommate Darnell likes an open door and people dropping in. For months each of them privately thought the other was a bit much, uptight in one direction, messy in the other. It came out one night over takeout. "I just like knowing who's going to be in the kitchen," Jasper said. Darnell said, "I just like it when *anyone* is." Fridays are open house now, and Sundays are quiet, or as quiet as Darnell can manage.

In your next disagreement, you might ask, "What matters to you about this?" and listen for the value under the position.

08

## Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again. How you say hello. Whether you keep small promises. How you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you.

An older man at the self-checkout can't get the card machine to take his card. The line behind him is growing and somebody near the back tuts, loudly. You're next, and you don't sigh. You say, "No rush." He says, "It's always this one, isn't it," and you agree that it is. The whole thing costs you about forty seconds.

**Kindness does something for the giver**

A meta-analysis of 27 experiments found that acts of kindness gave the person doing them a small-to-medium lift in wellbeing. The authors flagged worries about study quality, so take the size with a pinch of salt and the direction with rather less.

**Curry and colleagues (2018)** · *Moderate: the authors noted concerns about study quality and possible publication bias*

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it every day this week. You'll drift, as everyone does, and turning back is the practice.



SUGARFOOT

A value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what that is for each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: what feels like care
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction. When you notice you've drifted, you can turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

*On the back of an envelope you write people, health and making things, and under each one, a small thing for this week. Call Grandma, walk on Wednesday, finish the shelf in the spare room, the one that has been "nearly done" since Easter. The week is just as full as it was. You prop the envelope against the kettle, where it'll be the first thing you see.*

TWO WAYS TO READ THIS

### Values, two ways

BOTH DIRECTIONS Some people hold a value as a rule: honesty means saying the true thing, every time. Others hold it as a direction, adjusted to the moment. If you hold rules, the direction person isn't being slippery. They're weighing two good things at once. If you hold directions, the rule person isn't being harsh. A clear rule is how they stay steady.

WHERE THE FIELDS MEET Politics has a lot to say about two people with different values under one roof: a fair way to decide, and a say for everyone, and a way to change the rule later. The root is ownership and structure, plus quiet incentives, because a home drifts toward whatever it rewards.

## In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, security and adventure, say, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean very different things by it, from living around the corner to being free to go, so it's worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or some

volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

## If you want to help someone else with this

"What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud. "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than any lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

## Tools and reading on the website

**Tools helpers you use on the website**

- Your self-discovery path, step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

**A limit to keep in mind:** This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

## More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own · Empty nest · A new chapter after loss
- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together
- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family · Coming out as an adult
- **Friends and work:** Friends · At work
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens · Growing up
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

ONLINE
A new chapter after loss
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together



ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths



ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out



ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

## THIS CONNECTS TO


**Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 45
*Turning values into one small goal*

**Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair** — Share the Load, page 73
*Two kinds of fair*

**Book 3, Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture** — Understanding Each Other, page 95
*Whose values a group rewards*

**Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion** — Know Yourself Kindly, page 79
*Worth that is not a score*

PUT IT TO USE

**Your self-discovery path**

Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud

`spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path`

**Go deeper (free online)** The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values-in-depth`

# Questions people ask

*Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.*

### I lost my temper and said something I regret. Is it too late to put it right?

It rarely is. A short apology that names what you did, without a "but," and a plan for next time go a long way, even days later. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page **81**) shows how a repair goes, and Anger (Chapter 2, page **27**) has a pause plan for the next time the heat rises.

### Someone I love is grieving. What should I say?

Something simple and true, such as "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." Saying the name of the person who died is usually a kindness. Practical help, like a meal, a ride or a walk, often means more than the right words, and so does still being there a few months on. Loss, grief and big life changes (Chapter 4, page **65**) has more.

### I keep starting good habits and dropping them. What am I doing wrong?

Probably nothing, except starting too big. Habits stick when the first step is tiny, tied to something you already do and easy to restart after a missed day. Habits and change (Chapter 6, page **101**) shows how to shrink a step until it takes two minutes or less.

### Do I have to forgive someone who hurt me?

No. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time, and you can heal even if the other person never says sorry. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page **81**) explains what forgiving means and what it doesn't.

If you're having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone you trust today.

# Workpapers and tools in this book

*Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.*

## Workpapers mentioned in this book

*Pages to fill out, on your own or together.*

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Habits and change (page 101)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Anger (page 27), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Habits and change (page 101)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 117)

## Tools mentioned in this book

*Interactive helpers to use on the site.*

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder
In: Healing after hurt (page 81)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins
In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 117)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 117)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Anger (page 27), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65), Healing after hurt (page 81)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment
In: Anger (page 27)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks
In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Healing after hurt (page 81)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through
In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65), Healing after hurt (page 81)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask
In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 117)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive
In: Habits and change (page 101)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Healing after hurt (page 81)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Anger (page 27), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Habits and change (page 101), Values, meaning and a good life (page 117)

# Words used in this book

*The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.*

### Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

### Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

### Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

### Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

### Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

### The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

### The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

### My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

### Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

### Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

### Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable.

### Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

### Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

### Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

### Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

### Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

### Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill out on the website.

### Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

# How the ideas connect

*Many fields of study turn up in this book, from music to economics, and underneath them the same seven roots keep showing through. Learn a root once and you can carry it from one field to the next: if a budget needs a safety margin, so does a tired person.*

**Neurobiology**
Your state sets the volume.
Chapter 1

**Psychology**
Intent isn't impact.
Chapter 5

**Philosophy**
Separate the fact from the guess.
Chapter 4

**The art of debating**
Separate the claim from the person.
Chapter 2

**Politics**
A fair way to decide, and a say for everyone.
Chapter 7

THE SEVEN ROOTS

**Balance** what flows in has to match what flows out 4, 5

**Signal and noise** what's sent isn't always what arrives 2, 5

**Feedback loops** small things repeated, with a check each time, shape the whole 3, 6

**Limited capacity** everything has a limit 1

**Ownership and structure** work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one 7

**Quiet incentives** things drift toward whatever the setup quietly rewards 6, 7

**State and setting** the same message lands differently depending on the state you're in and the place you're in 1, 2, 3, 4

**Behavioral science**
Habits beat good intentions.
Chapter 6

**Economics**
Attention is a budget.
Chapter 1

**Finance**
Every entry has two sides.
Chapter 5

**Business**
One owner per job, and a simple check.
Chapter 6

**Holistic therapies**
Start with the body, then the argument.
Chapter 3

**Laughter therapy**
A shared laugh tells the body it's safe.
Chapter 4

**Music**
Tone and tempo carry more than the words.
Chapter 2

**Aromatherapy**
The setting matters.
Chapter 3

Holistic therapies, laughter and aromatherapy appear only in their plain, everyday parts. The research on them is modest or still growing.

# Research notes

The 149 studies and books these chapters mention, briefly. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

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